Wattlebird Bank: Strategy 2026 (board summary)

Wattlebird is a customer-owned mutual bank based in Newcastle NSW, serving 210,000 members across the Hunter and regional NSW.

Membership

Members under 30 fell from 19% of the base in 2021 to 14% in 2025. Churn among young members peaks between ages 23 and 26, usually within three months of a first full-time job, when salary is paid into another bank.

Most young members still hold the account a parent opened for them. The 2025 member survey did not ask under-30s why they stay.

Trust and scams

Trust scores are 8.4 out of 10 for members over 50 and 6.1 for under-30s. Scam losses doubled between 2023 and 2025 (board paper, p. 6). Older members report feeling rattled.

What has been tried

The 2024 app refresh lifted app store ratings from 3.1 to 4.4 but youth churn did not move. Three past youth offers were rate-led and none stuck.

Decisions and deadlines

The board paper requests a dedicated youth app, with no research attached. The new CEO, who started in July 2026, has asked for a clear direction by March 2027. Core banking cannot change before the 2027 migration.